

Purpose:

Players learn and practice what the back arm does during a swing.

Setup:

The player kneels at the side of a tee.

**Purpose:**

This drill helps players understand and practice the role of the front or lead arm during a baseball or softball swing, focusing on technique and form.

Setup:

Position a batting tee beside the player. The player should kneel on her back leg, aligning herself beside the tee, with her lead shoulder pointing towards the tee.



Player kneels at a tee to practice with her lead arm.

Instructions:

1. The batter kneels on her back knee, facing the tee with her lead shoulder.
2. Holding the bat in just the hand of her lead arm, she positions the bat at shoulder height, keeping her elbow bent and close to the body.
3. On the swing, the batter should focus on leading with the elbow, keeping it bent and driving the bat through the ball's plane on the tee.
4. Encourage the batter to maintain a straight torso throughout the swing to emphasize proper posture and avoid dipping the bat.
5. The swing should be short and compact, with a slight downward angle to promote a level swing path through the strike zone.
6. Instruct the batter to smoothly unlock the shoulder, then the elbow, and finally the wrist in that order during the swing, ensuring fluid motion and proper mechanics.
7. After contact with the ball, the batter should follow through, allowing the bat to naturally extend while maintaining control with the lead arm.

Coaching Tips:

- When using the lead arm, emphasize leading with the elbow and keeping both the elbow and the wrist bent, transitioning from high (shoulder level) to low (through the strike zone).

- Stress the importance of keeping the batter's torso straight, which aids in learning the importance of a level swing without dipping the bat.
- The swing should be short, compact, and with a slight downward angle to ensure a consistent, level path through the ball.
- Guide the batter to unlock the shoulder, elbow, and wrist sequentially for a fluid swing.
- For one-arm drills, it is recommended to use a lighter youth bat (16- or 17-ounce), which is easier to control with one hand.

Tips for Younger Athletes:

- Younger players benefit from repetitive practice to build muscle memory. Encourage them to perform the drill consistently, focusing on the mechanics rather than power.
- Use visual aids like colored tapes on the bat to indicate proper hand placement and swing path. This helps younger players understand the mechanics visually.
- Always provide positive feedback and encouragement. Celebrate their successes and offer constructive suggestions for improvement to keep them motivated.

Tips for Older Athletes:

- Introduce more advanced concepts such as the timing of the swing in relation to an imagined pitch. This helps older players to synchronize their swing with the pitcher's actions.
- Teach older athletes how to generate power from their lead arm by engaging their core and leg muscles, even in a kneeling position.
- Have them visualize various pitching scenarios and adjust their swing accordingly. This develops adaptability and prepares them for real game situations.

Player kneels at a tee to practice using her back arm.

Instructions:

1. The batter gets down on her back knee and swings the bat and hits the ball off the tee using just her back arm.

Coaching Tips:

- When using the back arm, it's important for the batter to keep a firm wrist and arm to keep the barrel higher than the hands as it comes through the contact area.
- On the swing, the batter should come down through the ball instead of dropping the bat first and then coming forward on a level plane.
- Raise the tee higher to test the batter's wrist strength.
- With the one-arm drills, it is best to use a youth (16- or 17-ounce) bat.

For Younger Athletes:

- Start with the fundamentals of the back arm swing, focusing on mastering the basic movement before adding power.
- Incorporate exercises to improve grip strength, as a strong grip is crucial for controlling the bat with one arm.
- Use positive reinforcement, acknowledging efforts and progress to build confidence and encourage development.

For Older Athletes:

- Introduce advanced techniques like adjusting the swing based on pitch location, helping develop a more versatile hitting approach.
- Challenge with heavier bats in the drill, if comfortably manageable, to help develop greater wrist and arm strength.
- Utilize video analysis for feedback, allowing older players to visually understand and correct their mechanics more effectively.